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Bernard Purdie

Drummer Bernard "Pretty" Purdie was born in Elkton, Maryland on June 11, 1939. He is often billed as "the world's most recorded drummer" and his list of associations include Aretha Franklin, Steely Dan, Dizzy Gillespie and Gato Barbieri. He has toured Europe with the Masters of Groove Trio and produced a video entitled "The Groove Master."

He was interviewed in West Orange, New Jersey on July 30, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in West Orange, New Jersey filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have Bernard Purdie here with me today. Thanks for driving and meeting with me.

BP: My plasma.

MR: You know I've met some versatile musicians doing this projects, but you go from Louis Armstrong to James Brown. I think that covers a lot of turf.

BP: Yes it does, it really does.

MR: Was there a point as a young man where you made a conscious decision to be a musician or did it just kind of evolve?

BP: As a young man my decision to be a musician was done as a baby.

MR: Really.

BP: Yeah. I was actually playing drums, tin pots, my mother and father, my parents they say at three.

MR: No kidding.

BP: I got my toy set at six. And it was just on from there. Because my teacher happened to be the drummer for the big band in Elkton, Maryland, which is the Cecil County School System. And he was a drummer. And I wanted to be like him. But he was also a teacher. And that's the one thing I didn't want to be. Whoa, was I so wrong.

MR: Really.

BP: Yeah. He told me that I was going to be a teacher. And I told him I do not wish that on anyone.

MR: Because you saw him in like a school system type of teacher? Or it was a private teacher? Or both?

BP: Both, actually for me. But being a teacher, he said the same things all the time. I mean you couldn't get around it. He said it day after day, week after week, month after month, year after year. And I said well how do you grow? I mean I don't understand. Why would you want to be a teacher — and not listening. That was my whole thing. I always said

they're not listening. Well I was wrong of course. But it's the one time that I can really truly say that I'm sorry that I was wrong, and I can admit that I was wrong. Once.

MR: That's a pretty good track record.

BP: Well that's been my biggest problem. That's been the biggest problem in the world for me. Coming up in the business I was never wrong. And people took that as a very bad attitude.

MR: Like they felt you were arrogant or something?

BP: Yeah. To one degree yes I was. But all that arrogance and stuff that I had, I really grew out of it. But the point was is that people didn't see that. They just knew that no matter what I said I believed in everything that I said. And it was always true. The truth always hurts. But the truth is something that's easy to come by. And it's something that you remember for life. The things that you have to make up gets distorted. And before you know it you lose your whole thought, what was I talking about, what, wow, what did I just do? You know you go away from what the truth is and what you fabricated dies. Oh yeah. The truth is something that will always be there because it's in your subconscious. And whether you read it, whether were involved with it or whether you were part of it, it does come out. You can recall anything. Your mind and your memory is remarkable. All you have to do is go back to it, think about it, and before you know it you're talking about what you lived and what you've been part of. And it's scary. And I mean really scary. Because there was a lot of people out there that didn't believe all the things I had done. Because it's easy for me to remember, to go back to, because I lived it. And boy oh boy oh boy, it has become part of the fun of writing on my book, all the good things.

MR: I can imagine. Yeah.

BP: The bad things you really want to forget and you really do try very hard to forget. But at the same time, they're there. And if you don't go through them, and doing, like the real biography and things like that, you don't get the hurt out.

MR: Do you think that your memory of the bad things — and I suppose the good things — are different at all from the other people that were involved? And do you need to speak to them if you're writing a book about how those things went down?

BP: Well let me put it to you this way. In some incidents I would say yes, you do need those kind of things. But I also found out that no, I really don't. I don't need to go back to ask them about what I had done, or do they remember what I did or whatever the circumstances were. Unh uh. The hurt is already there. Just remembering. But it also cleanses you when you get it out. And I do feel very good about all of the things that have happened to me. All the ups and downs that we go through that I've been through in the industry. It really hurt. Because I lost a lot of friends that I thought were friends and find out that they were associates. Big difference. But you don't know this as you're coming

along because you think they're friends. And when somebody is working with you or against you, they're not a friend. Working with you is one thing. Working against you or working for themselves is a whole nother ballgame.

MR: The times that those people that you thought were friends turned out not to be, was it usually a money issue? Power issue? Or can you pin it down?

BP: Well for me, I'd say 95% of the time it was a power issue. It wasn't even the money. Money makes power. But people who have money are really not interested or worried about making more money. They are interested in the power and what it does for them. And I got hurt a few times, I mean because of the power. I really truly did. But at the same time it was a major lesson for me that brought me through the business world. Because every time something happens — good, bad or indifferent — sshew, I could grab it and hold onto it. And it makes all the difference in the world when you can go back to it and relate to it, and just make yourself better, even if it hurts you, to stop somebody else from falling into that trap.

MR: That's really interesting.

BP: But I had good teachers. That makes the difference. It's the teachers who give you the body, the instincts and things like that that you don't have to be bitter, and you don't have to be bad, because it happened to you. You can actually make it comfortable for somebody else. And in the long run it will make it better for you. It makes you a better person.

MR: Who were the teachers that you would credit?

BP: Well my biggest teacher was Leonard Heywood. That was my first teacher and he was my music teacher, my drum teacher, he was the band director for the school, and my mentor.

MR: The last name was Haven?

BP: Heywood. Leonard Heywood. When I lost him, he moved to — well his wife said — moved to Phoenix, Arizona, for his health. Well I have no idea if that was true or not. As far as I'm concerned it was. Because she said it. But as time and the years go by it makes you wonder. Did they split up? He was an alcoholic, but of course I didn't know what that was. They said he had a breathing problem. Okay, Arizona was the dry place. I mean I had the whole spiel. It was all given to me. And I believed it. Totally believed it. I had never thought anything different. I had no reason to think that anything was different until 20, 30 years later, when you start asking and asking and then the things change on you. Well I just started hearing all kinds of stories. But who knows why? I was not that inquisitive to that point to want to know why they broke up, why they separated, why they divorced, whatever they did. I still have no idea. He was my mentor, he was my teacher, I loved him, and what I wanted to do was dedicate my book, my first book, and

anything else that I could do over the course of the years, to him. Because of what he did for me.

MR: That's nice.

BP: And still it will happen, and I'll just keep on doing it.

MR: Did someone step in to kind of fill that void for you when he left? Another teacher?

BP: Well actually it was more than that. Not one, not someone, but many. I ended up having many teachers because I looked at it that all my teachers in school, well not all, 90% of my teachers in school, I loved them. And they all were on my case. Now I thought that they were on my case for different reasons, until you find out that every one of them was there to help me. And they did help me. Because I could go back and relate to it, what they said, and then when other people, as the years went on would say wow man, that must have been a great lesson for you, and I went huh, oh yes, oh my God, they were helping me. I mean all of a sudden the light just shone, to how many people were helping me over the course of the years. And it was amazing. There was always somebody helping me. So I had to go back to find out why. And for me it was like you really are a nice guy. You are a pain in the neck, but you are a nice guy. And it was like okay, I can deal with this. Yes I know I'm realizing I'm a pain in the neck. But I never meant to harm anybody. I was always trying to do the job. And it was always the job first, because that's what I was taught. You do the job, then you have your fun. But why not do your job and have fun with it? That was my motto. Why can't I do both at the same time? And nobody said that you couldn't. He said but you must learn to watch your mouth. You've got a mouth problem. I had a very, very bad mouth problem of not bad words and things like that, not profanity. I just had a big mouth. I would jump in and stop other people from saying something and force my opinion.

MR: Okay. You had very strong opinions.

BP: Oh. Very strong opinions. All the time. I'd be no if, ands or buts. I have very strong opinions. And that was my problem. My opinions were always strong, but I was always right. Now I mean no matter how I look at it over all the years, if I practiced what I preached all the time it would be wonderful. But I didn't always practice what I preached. But believe me, I have very, very strong opinions.

MR: Well obviously at some point you must have butted heads with people who are much like yourself at the time, who also had strong opinions.

BP: I butted heads with a lot of them. And the reason why I'm still here today is that I didn't know how strong my opinions were, or how much I didn't know. My naïveness is why I'm alive today, and here. I mean yeah I have strong opinions but I was very, very naïve in my bad parts, or the negative parts. I mean I was like I didn't mean any harm in what I was saying, but I'm telling you that what you're talking about, music wise, that's what it

should have been. And my strongest opinion was always in the music and the music business.

MR: And you carry a lot of — as a drummer — you carry a lot of weight as to how things can end up.

BP: Yes.

MR: And the times when you were let's say butting heads with people, was it often times about the role of the drums and what you think you should play and what the leader or whoever, the singer, whatever — was that sometimes the conflict?

BP: Very seldom.

BP: No kidding.

BP: No. The conflict was where the music was going. How the music was being played. The audience that you're playing the music to, the concept of what the music was, I was so into the business world that sometimes I lost sight of what I was doing. But I never lost sight of where I thought the music should be and how to make hit records. Because I was with the buying public, I still bought records, I still liked the stars. I was able to pick out the hits because I enjoyed the music. So I had what most people called an insight. Because I listened to everybody. I listened to what people had to say. And then I'd make my opinions about it. But I also made it work musically and commercially. I was taught how to be a commercial salesperson early in life. Now I didn't know that that wasn't the way everybody else was doing things. You had a lot of people who just strictly was about the music. This is technically right. Okay. Fine. Yeah. I know that that note, you can play anything. If it sounds good it ain't wrong. And I mean I was taught that early. And people said no, no, no, no. Sometimes it's all about the voicing. It's all about how to make these chords go together and these notes. I said yeah, that's all good and fine. But does it feel good? Does it sound good? All right the bass player made a mistake. That didn't stop the record from being good. So you want to be perfect? Is that what you're saying? And I would be the first one to answer I'm sorry. I can give you a hundred records where there is a mistake, it's a hit record. So I was never super, super technical. All my life I was told that the music should feel good and should sound good, and it should be good. And that was my thing of how I was brought up. If you can't tap your foot, something is wrong. If you can't snap your fingers, something is wrong. If you can't move your body, something is wrong. And that to me, nothing technical about that. That is all about the love of the music. That is all about the love of the song and it's about things moving.

MR: It sounds like you had the instincts to be a producer and not just a drummer.

BP: Exactly. And that's what I was doing and I didn't know it. And that's where my mouth got me into trouble. And that's why I'm talking about being a big mouth. I will be the first one to jump up and tell the arranger and the producer and the writer that you're

wrong. And the part that hurts the most is that I was always right. They did not like it and I can't blame them. I mean it took me years to understand that, but the point was was that I just had this instinct. And I had it all my life, to make things work. Just make it work. Always thinking about making it work. Putting things together. I could always put things together. I could always put people together. I could always put places together. I could always. I mean I was a natural leader. But I was a great follower. And that's what you have to be. That's what I was taught. In order to be a good leader, you must be a great follower. Because unless you let the people know where you're going or where they're going, they're not going to follow you, for you to be a leader. You have to learn something about being a follower. So I had great teachers, and they showed me all those things as I was coming along. So I knew that I was a great follower. I didn't know I was a great leader. That took a long time for me to know and to understand that. And then of course my ego got in the way in the early parts of my life in the twenties. Because all of a sudden I'm doing all of this work and recording, and people are coming to me and wanting me to be on the date. And I always spoke up. I've never not spoken. Oh no. And one of the people that we talked about earlier, Bucky Pizzarelli, he was one of the first ones. He would sit over there and look at me and he'd say "go on, Purdie, go on, Purdie." And we'd just groove. We instantly hit it off, the first time that we were doing demos.

MR: Rock & roll type demos? R&B things?

BP: Yes, yes. We were doing that. And he was with that guitar and his body, you know his head, shoulders was happening. It wasn't all about his body and, but the foot was going. But it was just here. Woo. And that hand. I didn't have to look at his hand, I could see it. I could feel it. I could close my eyes and see him playing on the parts. Because I knew music. I didn't have any problem there. But woo, man, hit me deep, go right to the soul no matter what he played. And rhythm was the first thing that he would play, no matter what kind of melody that anybody wanted, he played rhythm first and then sneaked the melody in. But it was something else. I mean that to me is how you put folks together. You lock folks in. Guitar, bass, piano. The drummer — if he's got the bass player, which is of course for the drummer is number one, the bass player is number one — then he has to make a choice between guitar and piano as number two. You don't know which one is going to be number two until you play.

MR: Like Bucky.

BP: Yeah. And the thing is is that Bucky's on the date, Bucky becomes number two ninety-nine percent of the time. I don't care who's on the piano. When Hank Jones was on the piano I mean there's nobody can be any finer than him playing the piano and playing chords or playing rhythm or playing melody. But when Bucky and the two of them together I automatically lock in to Bucky with the bass player. And sometimes I ignored

the bass player if he wasn't strong enough because Bucky could carry it. But we always had good strong bass players around. So I mean I really learned about the music itself, of the feel. Yes I was never super, super technical. But when I had to be you talk music. You talk music and you talk shop, whatever it is, I could be on both sides of the fence. That's when I started to learn about what it meant to be a producer. A producer listens. You don't go in and say okay this is it, this is what we're going to do and you play this and you play that. Ah no, no, no. A good producer walks in and says, "Okay let's see what we got." Automatically. Let the rhythm section take you on a journey and find out if this is where you want to go. It really is that simple.

MR: Is it better for a producer not to be one of the players?

BP: Doesn't matter.

MR: Doesn't matter?

BP: It doesn't matter. The point is that a good producer is something that — he hears everything and only speaks when he needs to, and takes control when he has to. So he doesn't have to worry about bending the rules or it gets out of hand with Bucky saying one thing, George Duvivier saying something else and Bernard Purdie saying something else. No. If we're not locked in it's his job to stop it. Let's try it a different way. If he happens to be a player also, he knows. He is supposed to know what's going to work and what's going to work for him and lock in to make this music happen. That's his job. Number one job.

MR: And normally a producer will have — or maybe you can correct me if I'm wrong — but would a producer have been the person responsible for having those let's say four individuals in that rhythm section there? Because he anticipates that they're going to work well together?

BP: Exactly. Because they're in tune with one another. He's got to look at who's going to be in tune with one another. Now as big as my mouth, yes I know I have the biggest mouth going, the one thing that I never stopped doing is locking in to the rhythm section. I don't care which one I had, I don't care which kind of groove it was, because for me, as I was taught, music is music. Music is color. Music is sound. Music is all these things. But you've got to know what idiom that you're playing in. Jazz. Blues. Rock. R&B. Funk. Latin. It doesn't matter. You need to be able to play in all of them. And that means being able to read the notes. But in reading the notes you interpret the notes. That's what reading is to me. That's how I learned and that's what my teacher did. Interpreting the music, the notes.

MR: Some of the students that may watch this may have no idea what a record session is actually like. Is it possible for you to just describe it from that first phone call that you get

to show up at this particular date, and what that process is like? I know you've done so many in so many fields, but what is a typical recording session like?

BP: Okay. In order to do this you really need to know who the producer is. The producer himself or herself, whichever, it's the one person who knows what the end result is supposed to sound like. Not the arranger. The arranger only gets a certain amount. But it's the producer who is out with the artist that's with the writer that formulates what the song is going to be about. Not what it's going to be like, what it's going to be about first. So you have to have that the first thing. Then after you this then you go into a rehearsal. Go to where there's a keyboard or guitar or something and find out what the hook is. The hook is going to suggest who you're going to have in the band. Oh yeah. Because it's the hook that's going to be part of the sound and that sound can be a guitar sound, it can be a piano, it can be a synthesizer, it can be just a sound, a harmonica, it could be a vocal sound, it's a hook that's going to grab you, that's going to make folks want to like and to listen and to play this song over and over and over again. That's first. And then he goes to call the people that he wants on the session. Now years and years ago, fifties and sixties, you had everybody in the studio at once. So that meant that not only did the producer kind of know, but the arranger now kind of knows what this is going to be like in the end, because of all this music that's being written out. Well hit records were not made easy at that time because hit records at that time, when you had everybody in, could easily be re-written on the recording date. That's what happened. Something happened within the rhythm section. Ninety-five percent of the time something happened within the rhythm section which meant guitar, bass, drums, piano. And then coming back and going back where the sixties were you usually had only one drummer, one bass player, but you had three guitar players, one keyboard, maybe two, it varied. Then you have horns, strings, background singers.

MR: Which usually came later? Or were they—

BP: Oh no. This was all done at the same time. This was all done because we're now dealing with two and four track. Two track and four track. But that's — you know you're dealing with the early stages, the stuff that none of the young people today would know or understand because they didn't have to do it that way. They've never known anything like that. So going that way, what happened is that something happened within the rhythm section or a sound happened while you were in there. Now remember now, you already have this hook that you're looking at, at what you think is going to be the selling point. And that hook has to be now done and laid out. So that hook is going to be in. Now whether that hook is a two bar phrase, a four bar interlude or something that you're going to back to, back and forth within the song, we don't know. Nobody knows. But that is what they are selling. That's their selling point for the song. So you get into the studio,

you've got this rhythm section going and you start to create this sound. Something happens. Now you've got these three guitars. One is playing the backbeat (scats) and you've got rhythm (scats) and then you've got the other one might be a twang, it might be a thing with Vinnie Bell sound, water sound or a fish or a tree, a whistle. He had all kinds of little sound effects that he did. And this started to become part of the sound to go with the hook of what is happening, the thing that's going to be repeated over and over and over again. Well that's how things start to happen. Now for me, I was one of the lucky people. When I was coming along I never believed that the drummer had to be in the background. The drummer did not have to be in the background. Now Gene Krupa helped us. Gene Krupa was one of the first persons to bring us out front so people could see the drums. So I always felt that way because that's how I was taught when I was coming along. Yes I was taught to play, keep my time. But I was also trying to make the drums outstanding, to be remembered. And that's how things got with me, which is also why I had some problems with some of the music that was going down, and I was calling it old fashioned. At that particular time people like Bucky and Vinnie Bell and other folks, Bob Bushnell who actually played the Fender bass not the upright, just the upright sound, was coming into play. And it happened to come into what I liked, the kind of things that I did and something that I heard. So it was like wow, this is phenomenal. I'm not the only one that's hearing things. New thing. Different things. You don't have to play [scats]. You can play [scats] play it straight. Or you can play [scats] and really play it straight and come out with something that was a little bit different than [scats]. So ooh, I liked this. But still remembering what we were in there for, from what the producer wanted, the sound that the producer wanted to make this thing happen. I said okay, okay, all right, let's go, let's go with this. We tried something and the producer, you see the people, the horn players and the string players, they got lines and stuff that's going on that was happening and then we would ask, well mainly I would ask, if the string players and the horn players don't play for a minute. Give us five minutes to see if this rhythm is going to fit and maybe, just maybe the arranger might change the rhythm of what he wrote. Still get his figures, but change the rhythm slightly to make it go different and with a dotted feel. Well that was me a lot. That was part of my mouth situation. Well they would give us five minutes. We'd never get more than that, because time is money. We would try some of these things and sure enough these kind of things would happen. Your body started doing this and the arranger, especially if he's a smart one and really good one, if he starts, he says okay — so you don't want to go with the dotteds — okay — let's kind of play this a little bit more straight you know. But he could tell the musicians how to play what he wanted. It was his job.

MR: So you're talking about transitioning the music really from more of a swing thing into straight eighth notes.

BP: Yeah.

MR: Can you — this might be a hard question — but can you remember any particular sessions, particular songs where this kind of thing happened?

BP: Sure. Mickey and Sylvia.

MR: Oh. "Love is Strange."

BP: "Love is Strange." Yeah. See their first record, the first one that they did in the early fifties was mostly all swing. But it was re-recorded in '60, '61. I re-recorded it and brought it with a different sound. Almost straight. But if you hear the record that's been played all these years, for the last forty years, it's been their record of the straight time. Not the one that was the shuffle, but more of the straight time. Strings and all. The sound that they had with her moaning and doing two or three different sounds, having the background singers just follow her and not do things on their own. It made all the difference in the world. And that's the one that's been played for over forty years, that particular record. So I've been very pleased about things like that. "Just One Look," was my biggest record.

MR: Doris Troy?

BP: Yeah.

MR: I love that record.

BP: It was a straight, you know? I mean we had no strings and horns and stuff like that. We had background singers. And I came in because they couldn't find another drummer. They went around looking. This was a demo.

MR: I see.

BP: But those are the way things were happening and they were going on. So I got a chance to speak about what I was doing, what I would like to do and that was happening. And they allowed me to do it. So with all those years of running off at the mouth and all of a sudden records becoming hits, I got a reputation. So people gave me the benefit of the doubt of things that I was doing. I was doing something different. Yes he's got a big mouth, but was making hit records.

MR: So we could put up with it.

BP: We'd put up with it. When the date was over it was over. They didn't have to deal with me. They weren't going home with me. They knew this. I mean it was a business to them. But I didn't know. I didn't know that I was even alienating people. I mean I was even doing that. Because yeah I got a little arrogant with it after a while. But my arrogance was not like I didn't know what I was talking about. I was just happy. I was just a kid. I'm coming from nothing to coming to big time. So that's what my arrogance — when it

really happened to hit me, I started to make some money. I mean I was coming home from that $125 a week that I made for all of my work that I was doing, to making $125 a day.

MR: This was —

BP: In the sixties.

MR: In the sixties. So you would make how much for like a demo session or something?

BP: $10 a side.

MR: $10 a side. And how long would that usually take to do one of those?

BP: You did it — an hour.

MR: These are in studios in New York City.

BP: Yeah. And before you knew it I was walking home, like I said, with a hundred dollars, a hundred fifty dollars a day, going home. You know, not a week. And that was big money to me.

MR: What kind, how did the session change so that it became that $150 a night. Were these now record label sessions?

BP: Well the record label sessions were $42.50 for three hours. So if you did two or three sessions during the course of a day, that's $150 almost $150, because also they were supposed to pay health & welfare and pension. Well you find out much, much later in life that they weren't.

MR: Oh boy.

BP: Yeah. Well that's what I'm fighting now so, but it's going to be okay, it's going to be okay. It's all in my favor now. But we even have documentation now.

MR: But if one of these sessions turned out a hit record, the guys in the band did not get more money.

BP: No. We never got more money. We got paid for what we did. And that's why I thought and every time I would speak up — I was always right when I spoke up, I didn't just jump up and say no let's do it this way. I listened to everybody. I listened to everything that went down. And if it wasn't happening then I'd have something to say. And they did listen to me, the producer, the arranger, the writers, the artists. They did listen. The musicians resented it because well most of the time I didn't do it right. I really didn't.

MR: Your delivery of your —

BP: I had no delivery. I am sorry, I had no delivery. It was bad. It was really, really bad. I'd stop guys, no, no man, no it's wrong.

MR: Okay. Yeah, I can see.

BP: I'm sorry. Then I'm saying I'm sorry, but no man it's not like that.

MR: It must have hit you, like your musical barometer just something would strike you to be so wrong that you just couldn't resist.

BP: Yeah. I couldn't. And it happened all the time. See that's the thing. I get totally upset. I mean my body, my hands and my face said it every time. And when I tried to control it and not say something I'd be sitting at the drums and my face — the guys used to tell me I had more facial —

MR: He's got his face on.

BP: We're getting ready to go through this again and he don't like something. And I tried my best not to say something but it was all over my face. So the arranger or the producer would go, "All right Purdie, what's wrong?" I said, "Well you asked me. Well you know we really didn't do that section right, there was some mistakes, and the rhythm wasn't the right rhythm that should have been played over here, and this shouldn't have been done here, and this here and this." And I would rearrange the song. And they'd look at me and the musicians, God dammit Purdie. They wouldn't say nothing, they'd just look at me. They wanted to kill me.

MR: Were you ever responsible for sending sessions into overtime?

BP: Once in a while. Not often. Because I was one of the first people that would tell 'em "now people we've got to go, we've only got five minutes." Five minute break. Ten minute break. I was back sitting in my chair ready to go. So once in a while it might be me. And then if it was me, even the musicians wouldn't mind so much. If we went five minutes over, we would not charge them. Or even ten minutes over. We might not charge them. But if we had the string players and the horn players they're going to get charged no matter what. Because somebody is going to tell. Nobody is — I'm not, or it's okay, invariably, every time, somebody would go and tell.

MR: That's very interesting. Do you think there's a different kind of camaraderie with rhythm section players than there is with — I don't know, the players who just come in and they get the music set in front of them, and every note is there that they're supposed to play. There's not as much creative outlet for them. And I think it affects their attitude to the music.

BP: Yes. Yes it does. And those ninety percent of the time would be the ones that would turn you in. So we couldn't say that okay it was the string players or it was the horn players, but we know that nobody in the rhythm section did it, because we wanted things to be happening. And even if they made a mistake it didn't matter because it didn't affect the rhythm, didn't affect the sound, didn't affect the feel. They could bury part of the sound of that mistake but when the rhythm was right everybody else had to go along with the program. And I was right one hundred percent of the time. Not ninety-eight, not ninety-nine. I was right one hundred percent of the time going along for all those years. When I made a mistake everybody knew it. Everybody knew it. And everybody would turn and, "Hey Purdie" they've all got something to say. I'd say, "Okay, okay, all right, that's

enough." Oh they knew how to get me back. Everybody did. When I made a mistake everybody knew I made the mistake. No ifs, ands or buts about it. It was just what it was.

MR: In those days when everybody was there on the session, did that include the singer?

BP: Um hum.

MR: Okay. So you really got to hear how what you were playing and what the rhythm section was playing was interacting with the whole thing. Now years later when all this is done in sections, is it different? Because you may not ever hear those horn parts and those string parts.

BP: That's right. So what I had to do was figure out what the arrangement was going to do. This is where my creativity came in. This is how I really became the star of all those recordings and things in the late sixties, seventies. Because I was creating part of the rhythms and the melody and the counterrhythms that was going to be set up for horns and strings and background singers.

MR: Well how did you get to know where that was going to come in?

BP: Because the singer would be there on the date. They would let them sing as we were running and rehearsing the song down. So I now got part of the melody. I got now the melody. Okay, I see where you want to go. And now it's time for me to take the rhythm section and build the rhythm section around the melody and to become part of — for the singer to be center, and then build all these different kind of rhythms and counterrhythms around it. So yes, I became very intricate — a very intricate part of what the song would be. And the drums became very important. Bass became even more important. Guitars became even more. And of course the keyboard wasn't just the piano anymore, they got some synthesizers and organs being put on. So yes, my influence was very, very heavy into what was going on. Because then I really learned how to put all this music together. Now I became an arranger, not only — I became a writer, arranger, producer. I really became all of those. But yet I wasn't around when the horns were put on. I wasn't around when the strings were put on. But what we had put down within the realm of the rhythm section laid the foundation for everybody else to sit on the throne with us. Because then I really was driving the vehicle.

MR: That's very interesting. So often times you might not hear the final product. You might be in your car driving along and the first time you hear that song that you played on might be on a car radio?

BP: Yeah. And to give you a good example, one of the best examples in the world is Aretha Franklin. "Oh Me Oh My," "Until You Come Back to Me," I mean I can — "Rock Steady," "Daydreaming," "Think." I mean all these things happened after the rhythm section was put down. But I got it from her. When she sat down at the piano and played the melody. And where she wanted things to happen and to go. And I was dictating to

everybody — by this time I mean I'm hot stuff now man. Oh this Bernard Purdie man. I got all this stuff now. I mean I'm good at what I do, people know I'm good at what I do, so I'm going to get the respect of what I say they're going to try and don't let me have no frown or something on my face. "Oh my God Purdie don't like it. He's the hit maker. If he don't like it, it ain't right." I mean I had that kind of reputation. So I had to keep my reputation going. And as they say the rest becomes history. Because this is what happened. But during those times is when I really started to learn — not to holler across the room at the trumpet player, "You made a mistake at bar four" such and such. Oh my God. Ernie Royal used to want to kill me. I'm serious. Ernie Royal wanted to kill me. Because he was always on the date because I made sure that he was. I mean I was a contractor so I knew who was going to be coming in and such and such. And I used to holler over at him, "Ernie, you know you're playing the wrong note, why don't you play the right note at bar" so and so and so and so. And just like that. It was really that simple. That's what I used to do. And they looked at me and said pay him no mind. He just can't help himself. He just can't help himself. And they did. And when the date was over we were all out eating together. We all are doing things together, and such and such and such, and it was over, it was all over, it wasn't nothing, nothing was held on after the date was over. Ernie might walk up and hit me upside the head, "Purdie leave me alone." I said, "All right, Ernie, you know I love you, you know I love you." And never thought anything of it, you know, really. It was over. It was said and done, it was over. I didn't know that certain arrangers and certain producers really resented that.

MR: And did they start not calling you?

BP: They didn't stop calling me, not right away. Not until they found somebody else that could do what I was doing. And that took years. By then I had a reputation and somebody else would call me. So I didn't know that I was losing out on anything, and I didn't know that I was creating a problem with some of my clients. I just didn't. But see that was also part of my naiveness. I didn't mean any harm at what I was doing because I wanted it right. And I felt responsible. Because fifty to sixty percent of those sessions I was the contractor or I was made the leader. So I just wanted it to be right. Always wanted it to be right. So I didn't think in terms of something being wrong or that I had done something wrong.

MR: Uh huh. You're just doing your job.

BP: Yeah. And it was a job.

MR: Who were the people in the key positions, the bass player, the guitar and even like the tenor sax soloists that you liked to see on the date?

BP: King Curtis was the tenor sax soloist. Sam "the Man" Taylor, David Newman, Marshall Royal. I mean all these guys were all legends to me. And guitar players was Mickey

Baker, Eric Gale, Hugh McCracken, David Spinozza, Vinnie Bell, Wally Richardson. I mean these guitar — and Bucky Pizzarelli. I mean for me I could not have ever asked for anybody any better than those musicians. I mean there were hundreds that you could go along with the program with and have them on the date and it would automatically turn out. But you had to know who you put together. It was the people that you put together that liked one another that made things happen even when the music was wrong they wouldn't play it wrong. They just wanted to be — yeah, not in the rhythm section. Horns? Ahh see the horn section and the string section, until that arranger would want to change it or correct it, they'd just go and play it.

MR: They wouldn't say anything if it sounded off.

BP: No. And that's what I used to come down on see. That was the thing that I was hollering across the room, oy yoy yoy.

MR: Okay so he might have been playing what was on the page.

BP: Yes he was.

MR: But it wasn't what should have been there.

BP: And I would tell them, "You know you're playing the wrong note, why don't you just change it?" And I was good at that. I was hollering all across the place. I was always hollering across the place.

MR: In your book, you said you're working on a book, will it have a discography?

BP: Yeah. We're going to have — I'd say we're probably going to have anywhere from twelve hundred to two thousand.

MR: Sessions or records?

BP: Records and sessions, different records. We should have at least that. What the young man is doing now, Ed Dennis, I mean I have about four or five hundred that I've always had.

MR: Actual LPs?

BP: Yeah. LPs. Oh man he's — 45s — LPs that I've totally forgot. One time LPs with people. I mean it's just ridiculous. It's absolutely ridiculous that I just didn't remember. And then when I heard this — oh I know this, oh this was so-and-so. I mean all of a sudden it just came back to me or who's it was and who's date it was. And that's what happened during the course of him finding records that he's found from other people that he's been doing on the internet.

MR: Man, that's something.

BP: Well the Internet is a good thing but the internet can also be a bad thing. Because there is a lot of stuff that's on the internet that didn't happen. And people are taking credit for a lot of stuff that they didn't do. Because somebody went out and did some work and started writing some information and they thought that this was what was going on. They

didn't do all their homework. But yet they're making a fortune behind putting somebody else's name on it. And some of that is also now being corrected.

MR: Good. Well I was going to play, actually, a tune that you played on, and I want to see if you can remember what it is.

[audio interlude]

BP: Well it sounds like the original was done by Little Esther. I did the original. Little Esther Phillips. "To Be Free." Nina Simone — I did the first one with Nina in '64.

MR: This is actually Shirley Scott I think.

BP: I know. I was coming to it. But I'm just trying to tell you—

MR: Or you're giving me the whole — that's great.

BP: Yes.

MR: So it's funny with you, it's not just that you played on that one, you played on all four versions of it. That's terrific.

BP: Yeah. But see that's what happens. Now I can't tell you why all the other things just came up. And I can just say it because it happened. That's what I mean by what's in the memory bank. When you hear something. Something strikes up and then all of a sudden you go back to what you did originally. And I find that yeah, there are four different versions that I did that were all hits by the different people. And then you pick out one that wasn't necessarily a big hit for her but yet yeah, it was me also. And that's a nice feeling for me, that people are finding those kind of records. And that's what he's been doing. He's been finding records that do have some information on them.

MR: Because the '45s didn't.

BP: Exactly. But there was people in recording studios who now have been putting down documentation of what — all these other books and stuff that's been written by different people, the documentations of interviews of other people who've been talking about me for umpteen years. And there is it. So it's a really, really nice feeling for me to find that these kind of things have been happening. And boy I'm telling you, my book is dynamite. I really like what he is doing. Even with the bad stuff, it's good. I'm tickled pink. I'm serious. I'm tickled pink about it. It's another ballgame for me.

MR: We didn't talk much about your childhood. What music were you hearing in your house when you were a little kid?

BP: Gospel, country, blues. And western. And all kinds of things like that. One of my all-time favorites is the Floyd Cramer. I'm country — I just love country music. Always did. And the funniest part, here's what people used to laugh at me when I used to say Ray Charles is country. And they'd say what are you talking about, Ray Charles — Ray Charles ain't country. I'd say Ray Charles is country. Every song that Ray Charles has recorded has

been a country song. It's that simple. He likes melodies. He likes strong lyrics that have meaning, and that's what you get from country. It's really that simple.

MR: Well you know I can see why you would — with what you've said about just the groove of a song and the meaning of a song — why you would like something like Floyd Cramer. Because it's not about technique and lots of notes, it's just about the simplicity and nice feel.

BP: And that's what I had to do all my life. Learn to be simple. When I play I play simple. I am right down the middle. And I know how to go from one side to the other without a problem. I don't have a problem. Because I'm going to be the simplest person in there. But yet I'm going to groove with it. That is part of my whole life. All my life I was taught that. I was taught that's what you need to do, that's what you need to focus on. You focus in on the music. You focus everything about what you have to do. And that's the ABCs of the music business. But I really did. I learned about the music business. It wasn't just being a player. If it was just being a player I'd have been what I would call a superstar. I'd have been a James Brown with the instrumental thing and being the artist. I'd have been there umpteen years ago. But I play every kind of music so I have always wanted to play every kind of music. And I brought you a CD that really shows ten different ways, at least ten different ways of Bernard Purdie.

MR: Great.

BP: Big band, little band, small band, disco, country, R&B, pop, reggae, Brazilian, Latin. It's all there. And it took me ten years to do because I got solos from all the friends that I wanted, like Dizzy Gillespie, Grover Washington, Jorge Dalto, Freddie Hubbard, the list goes on and on and on or who's who in the music business. And I kept tracks that I've kept over the course of the years up to a forty piece orchestra. And I've even done the vocals on some because I wanted a simple melody. I didn't want all the curly cues that most vocalists want to do first.

MR: Even more so nowadays, right?

BP: Yeah.

MR: It seems like the young R&B singers I hear really — curly — that's a good word for it.

BP: They're curly cues. That's just plain old curly cues. That's all it is. So you know it's just one of those things that happened and I'm pleased. I'm just very pleased that I've learned to go along with the program. But I've also learned how to be a little mellow with things. I've gotten pretty good. Structure-wise and everything else. And people doubt — people look at me when I tell them yeah I'm arrogant. And they say well we know that. I said oh man, you're going to spoil my whole day I can't even be arrogant anymore. I'm starting to be like I was thirty, forty years ago. "Purdie, forget it." I mean that arrogance is out the window. No. It's just not there anymore. It's not even about that. I like what I do. I'm

good at what I do and I enjoy what I do. And that's the arrogance as far as it goes. I know now that everything that I do is not going to be one hundred percent totally the right way necessarily. I've got to bend. You've got to bend the rules sometimes now.

MR: A couple percent.

BP: So I lose a few percents. But it's okay.

MR: You can live with that now.

BP: I can live with it. I couldn't forty years ago. It was a problem to me forty years ago. I couldn't walk out the — I'd be totally upset and then I've had producer come, "No, no, no, let's get it right." I said, "But the time is up." "We'll pay the overtime." Yeah I've had them do that. But then of course it was right. I was right and we came back in and we did it and we made hit records with that half hour overtime that we got that they paid for. But it was nice. It was a learning experience. It's something that I'll never ever forget. And there's no way of trying to give it all to somebody at one time in one sitting. It's just not there, it's too much. It's too much going. And it's going to take years and years and years to get things out of what really happened and why there's been a major change and a fluctuation to go back to. The music industry itself is hurting. It's really hurting. And the big guys did it to themselves.

MR: Listen, we need to change tapes here. Have you got another fifteen minutes for me?

BP: Sure. I'd be glad to.

MR: I'm not sure when you have to —

BP: I'm fine.

MR: Good because this is real fascinating stuff. Oh you did it.

What's the state of the music industry today?

BP: The state of the music industry today — the words that I would like to use is not very cool. And one of them starts with an S. It's really that bad. But the big guys have done it to themselves. Greed is what messed up the music industry. When you start making profits of, instead of single digits, making profits over the course of the years, what caused them to be as big as they are anyhow, and when you're making four or five hundred percent in the course of a year, it can mess you totally around. So they just became super, super, giant, giant. And then they started grabbing up everything that they could and not losing anything because there was so much money that they made. Well the problem was, and is, is that too many songs have no melodies. And people who write melodies are not around much anymore. They're making sounds. Sounds is what's selling and has been selling in the last ten, fifteen years. Not melodies. So — and don't get me wrong now — the Rappers have come in and made a name for themselves. But what they did was take from what happened thirty, forty years ago, and they've saturated us now to

the point is that people are now tired of hearing the one note, as we used to call it the "One Note Samba." But the "One Note Samba" has a melody.

MR: Right. And it breaks into a bridge that releases that.

BP: Thank you. Well the way songs are done today and written, nobody can remember any of them. Because it's all rhythms. Nobody remembers the words. Yeah you have a few of the kids who remember the words. But what it is is that the record people have made millions and millions and millions of dollars on the rappers. So consequently it's shrinking because people that were rappers twenty, fifteen years ago, are not adult — adults. So you've got adult contemporary and they want more. They can't be that youngster that they were. And then the kids that are growing up with them don't want them, don't want the parents with their music, because they want to be something different. Well the kids today are not any different than what it was in the sixties or the seventies or the eighties. The point is is that they're trying to make their own. They have nothing, so they're trying to create something from something that was already done and it's already happened so they're having problems. So they're wasting time and money. So they're not making the big bucks, the two, three, four hundred percent. All of a sudden the profit is coming down to double digits and it's coming down to single digits again. So consequently the industry is hurting because the people who gobbles the money when they — dividends — are not getting it. They're making money but the dividends are smaller. So people want to go where there's bigger, better dividends. I'm sorry, it's just not out there. Until they go back and now start getting people with melodies, that songs stay and linger for thirty, forty, fifty, a hundred years. Why do you think everything is revival? Look at what happens. Nobody is making money on something new. It's all about revival.

MR: Jazz reissues and all those kinds of things.

BP: Everything. The jazz reissues they made gobbles of money. They didn't have to pay anybody. So people like myself who also made records in the sixties and the seventies, my records, took off. Took off. Columbia, Prestige, Flying Dutchman. Those labels are owned by the big guys and they are making money with them. I finally got paid, twenty years later, twenty years later, from 1972, the record that I made on Prestige. 1972. '71 and '72. They started paying me in '94 because I was smart enough to go in and say I want an audit.

MR: No kidding.

BP: Then all of a sudden, bam, the $4,445 they said I owed them for twenty years got paid. Now in the eighties — they were making money on my records in the late eighties. Millions. I find this out. I don't get it. But they started making money and it was like what is happening? Of course you see revival — people were calling me from Europe

and they wanted my old records. They wanted my albums. I said my albums? I said, "But I'm making CDs." "No, no, we want your albums." That's when I find out. And I'm selling. All my old stuff is selling. So I started to watch the industry a lot more. And a lot closer. As I was going along I saw what was happening and I saw how the big guys basically just kept getting bigger and bigger and bigger until the bubble started to burst and it was bursting because the people that they have running the companies were not musical people. They were lawyers. Lawyers were running the companies by the numbers, the books. How many units did we sell? What did we sell? It's all about selling. It's not about the quality. It's all about the quantity to them. How much is the bottom line? We don't have to pay for this do we? We got this. And that's what they did. So they flourished for a lot of years. That last ten years, man serious trouble. Because they have nothing new. And everything they have new has gone by the wayside. They're not selling millions. They might sell a hundred thousand, two hundred thousand, half a million units. But the money that they've already spent is not covering. Because you've got so many other people that are coming in and other little companies that are siphoning from them from the bottom. Because they're not up there in their ivory towers, they're down here and folks like me who are actually surviving and having a nice survival are actually earning a good living. Decent and good. You don't have to sell a hundred thousand units to make ten or twenty thousand dollars. And you have to ask yourself, what do you mean, how come you don't — because you can sell ten thousand units and make twenty thousand dollars. What? What? What are you talking about? Yeah.

MR: What's the technology done—

BP: Technology has hurt them and it's helped them. The only way for them to survive what they're doing, they're making it on technology. They are actually selling more blank tapes and CDs than they are songs and records and CDs. They're actually selling more blanks. They are making their money selling blanks.

MR: So people can download.

BP: And they all talk about the download, that they're not getting paid. They're getting paid. They're not getting paid enough as far as they're concerned. So they are still making the money on the blanks. And it's only the big guys who make the blanks. The little guy can't. He can't because he can't survive because he's still got to buy from the big guy because they own the plants. So if you're going to buy what they call off the rack it's going to cost you. When you buy a blank today, you buy ten blanks. You buy fifty blanks. You buy a hundred blanks. But how much does it cost you? Is it a dollar a blank? Is it two dollars a blank? Is it fifty cents a blank? It all depends on how many you're going to make and how many you're going to sell. How long is it going to take to sell them? So the big guys are still making the money. It's all about control. That's what it is.

They made the units to whereas we want something, people are not going to make more than a hundred blanks a year for selling purposes. They're not making them for selling purposes, they're making them to give away. Because it becomes expensive. Just buy blanks and make a blank for your friend. But it's a hobby. It's not a business. So a little guy with a little record label, if I sell five or ten thousand units I'm doing quite well. Well I've been doing that for some time and staying away from the big guys and how I've survived and still be able to chill out. And still be able to play music and not have all the problems that most people have of staying healthy or being able to travel around the world and enjoy yourself and have a good time doing it. I'm doing that. And I am enjoying it. I like meeting the people. I like being on both sides of the fence. So it's okay because I'm just being me. Well the big guys are now looking at me. And it's a little scary. But I'm ready for them now. I'm ready to say okay, all right Dad, take care of me. I'm ready now. I'm ready to accept the inevitable. It's okay. You know I had a little fun, it was good, I enjoyed myself, I'm ready to get in line and follow and do what you tell me to do.

MR: Let me ask you about a couple — obviously we can't talk about everybody you've played with, but the years spent with Aretha. What was it like?

BP: To me it was great years. I had more problems than a barrel of monkeys on the personal side but that's what I had to learn to live with. Aretha is one of the best, one of the best performers in the world. Not great with business and personal life she's had all kinds of problems. It affected me and everybody else around her. Tragic-wise it's something that you have to deal with if you're going to deal with the person. Aretha to me has always been wonderful. I love her and to me I love her from a distance. Because when I have to run I'm going to be able to run and get away from her. But that's something that's personal and the business and the personal thing doesn't quite work hand in hand with her. So you just have to know how to deal with it. Steely Dan? I didn't have a problem. Steely Dan was one of the hardest groups in the world for me to work with, but I don't have that problem of working with people. I leave them alone. I go in, I do my job, and I leave.

MR: Well those guys are pretty controlling in the studio, is that right? That's what I've heard.

BP: Oh yes. But it's like anything else, you do your job and that's all they want. And it works. They'll allow you to do what you do.

MR: And they didn't call you by accident, that's for sure. Right?

BP: That's right.

MR: I mean they wanted you in that seat.

BP: But see I didn't know — you go by the reputation of the things that you hear, even before all these things happening. And for me I said oh, okay. It didn't matter. It didn't matter

who the artist was as far as I'm concerned. An artist is an artist. You go in, you do your job, and you leave. Now if you're lucky enough to socialize with them on the outside after the job is done, great, fine. But it is not a way of life. I enjoy the artists. I enjoy all the names. I enjoy all the unknown names. They pay me to come in to do a job. That's what I'm going to do. I'm going to do the job, and I'm going to get out of your way. Now our paths cross further down the line it's always going to be a very nice thing. Because it's going to be the same. Talking about bad or something? What am I going to talk about that's bad? What did we do that was so bad? I don't know all the problems that you have of such and such and such. But you didn't hurt me. And if you did hurt me, I'll leave you alone. It's that simple. I don't have to go and really go through all the changes of being hurt again when I know that you're going to hurt me. For what? For money? I can make money when I can't do anything else. I know how to make money. But I am good at what I do which is what gives me the opportunity to make money. Hall & Oates, Simon & Garfunkel, Roberta Flack, Donnie Hathaway, everybody. When I really look at the overall picture I've had more fun than a barrel of monkeys. James Brown was a pain in the neck. When I had to do what I had to do to show my butt with him, I did it and it was over. You go in and you do your job. But that's what it is for me. That's how I was taught. That was the thing that was instilled in me first. If you don't like it don't accept it. You don't do the job. I had to tell Barry Manilow — you want Steve Gadd? I'll go call him. Hey, you don't — don't take me through these changes that, well you know you're now — we're big time Purdie so I said no, no. I was there when you were nothing. I was there when you were doing demos. That's how far back I go with it. More power to you that you're the biggest cheese out here. Wonderful. But like I said before don't ask me to play like Steve Gadd. Because I am not Steve Gadd.

MR: And he's not you.

BP: Exactly. You want Steve, you call him. I'll be glad to call him for you. But you know when I was coming along I didn't know that that's the way it was. You had to play like somebody else in order to do that. Well I didn't. I played me. But I played and did the job. Now I was fortunate enough to have enough in me to do the job plus. That's what I've done all my life. Do the job plus stick a little bit of me in. And that's how I've done over all these years. I'm going to go in and I'm going to do the job. I'm going to play the music and then I'm going to add a touch of Purdie. Now I thought that's what you called me for. And after all these years I'm still doing the same thing. I'm still doing the job. But I thought you wanted a little bit of me. And that's how I do it. So if that means that I'm still arrogant, fine, I'm still arrogant. The point is that I'm there to do the job. I will always love Aretha, the Rolling Stones, Hall & Oates, Steely Dan. I'm always going to love them — B.B. King — like a father to me. The point is is that they called me to do a

job and I said yes I can do it. That's what I'm going to do. But I get along with everybody and no matter who it is. Cissy, Whitney, it doesn't matter. That to me is part of life. That's why I'm in the position that I'm in, that's why I like everybody, that's why I can talk about everybody. But I always have something positive to say. Now I could go and I could have made a million dollars instead if I'd have talked about all the bad things about Aretha while I was there. For what? Then I'd never work.

MR: You wouldn't feel good about yourself either.

BP: Not only that but nobody would hire me to play.

MR: Yeah.

BP: I says no, no, no, no, no, no, no, no, no. Money? I can still earn a good living. So no, no, no. Can't go that route.

MR: Well listen you've been called and you are the world's most recorded drummer. If we could assemble a rhythm section of the world's most recorded individual people, who would be playing with you? Do you suppose Milt Hinton would be there?

BP: Well yeah, yeah. Ooh. Wow. Yes Milt Hinton would be. He would definitely be. And then you have folks like people that they forgot about. Bob Bushnell. Bob Bushnell was the first to crack from the upright bass to the Fender. Yeah. Ooh. He did it. And he was the first to do it for ten years. He was doing it almost ten years before it really became popular. So and then you've got Bucky Pizzarelli on guitar, you've got Eric Gale, I put them all in the same category. Piano, Hank Jones. Jorge Dalto, Richard Tee. I mean, and Paul Griffin.

MR: Oh yeah, I forgot about him.

BP: Well I did so many dates and things with each one of them and Paul Griffin of course we were together with Steely Dan. Larry Carlton, Paul Griffin, Chuck Rainey. I mean you're talking about the cream of the crop of musicians who could play anything but played what was necessary for what was asked of them at the time. See that's the beauty. That to me is what it's about. That's why I can go anyplace anywhere in the world and play with anybody. Because I know the rhythms. It's that simple. And you've just got to play the right rhythms with what folks want.

MR: It sounds simple. It takes talent that's for sure.

BP: Well it takes talent but you have to work at what you're doing for a lot of years. When you work at it and do what needs to be done it works. It definitely works. And it is not a problem for it not — to happen. But you've got to know your craft. And that's all it is. You learn your craft first and then you do it afterwards.

MR: Well just to wrap up here, do you want to tell me how your nickname came about?

BP: When I first came to New York people could not pronounce my last name. They were calling me Bernard Pretty. And after six months the Bernard got dropped and it was

Purdie, hey Pretty Purdie. Pretty Purdie come here. And it was that kind of thing. In the beginning I took it wrong. But after a while it just made sense. It was a good rhyme. There was a good rhythm. It was a good feel. And I liked it, I mean I really and truly liked it. So it was given to me in 1961. I mean I've had it since then. And it was something that layed nicely. And like I said when I finally was able to get my name back it was close to the eighties. It was like I started like 1977. I want my name back. Bernard is my name. And people said well we know you as Pretty Purdie. I said yeah, it's Bernard Pretty Purdie. And they said oh, okay, that's fine, as long as you keep the Pretty in because that's what we're selling. And it was a selling point. So it was cool. So like I said when I first came they couldn't pronounce my last name and it was Bernard Pretty. And then Pretty Purdie. Like that. Catchy. Or some people would just say hey Pretty. And I mean you know that that's somebody who really didn't know me and somebody was trying. Because somebody that knew me would say Purdie, would call me by my last name. So after a while everything was fine and then late eighties and nineties it was just Bernard Purdie. I didn't have to worry one way or the other, but I decided to keep it because there were people who still knew me as Pretty Purdie. So I said well it's there, it's now permanent, it's Bernard "Pretty" Purdie. And that's why I use it, the whole thing.

MR: Well I want to tell you it's been a real privilege to talk to you today, and I have enjoyed it immensely.

BP: My pleasure.

MR: I want to wish you the best on your book.

BP: Oh I'm so happy. I really am. It's nice.

MR: Well thanks for your time today.

BP: Thank you. My plasma as they say. Well that's what I say. I still like that.

MR: Sounds good.

BP: It is. It's very good.